

FRESHWATER® SALT SYSTEM

Clean, soft, natural-feeling water for up to a full year — with far fewer chemicals.

WHAT IT IS

A patented salt-to-chlorine system built by Watkins Wellness exclusively for Hot Spring spas. A small amount of salt is added to the spa water; a replaceable titanium cartridge uses electrolysis to convert that salt into a continuous, low-level supply of chlorine — about 1 ppm, similar to drinking water. The result is soft, natural-feeling water with no harsh chlorine odor, no itchy skin or eyes, and far less bottled chemical use than traditional spa care. The titanium cartridge lasts up to four months and is replaced in seconds with no tools and no draining. With proper care and balanced water, spa water can last up to a full year — up to 3–4× longer than conventional systems.

HOW IT WORKS

1 ADD SALT

Target ~1,750 ppm salt. Jets on.
Add one cup at a time into the filter compartment. Verify with FreshWater Salt test strips.
Do not exceed 2,000 ppm.
Start with half the chart amount.

2 CARTRIDGE GENERATES

Titanium cartridge converts salt into chlorine 24/7 via electrolysis. System self-sanitizes most of the time. Output controlled from the spa panel (levels 0–10).
Boost runs Level 10 for 24 hours.

3 MONITOR & REPLACE

Panel guides output level and Boost. 10-day checkup reminder flashes on the water care icon. Replace titanium cartridge about every 4 months in seconds — no tools, no draining required.

KEY BENEFITS

Water lasts up to 1 year

Drain and refill far less often — up to 3–4× longer than traditional spa care when water is balanced and maintained properly.

No harsh chemical odor

Water smells clean and fresh — more like the ocean a than heavily chlorinated pool. More inviting for family use.

Simple maintenance

Replace the titanium cartridge about every 4 months when prompted. Control panel guides output levels and checkups.

Softer on skin & eyes

Low-level natural chlorine means no dry, itchy skin — or red, irritated eyes ideal for daily soakers and sensitive skin.

Fewer bottled chemicals

System self-sanitizes most of the time. Less shock, less manual dosing, lower ongoing chemical cost and storage.

More time enjoying

Less testing, balancing, and adjusting means more the time actually using spa for hydrotherapy and relaxation.

SALT SYSTEM WATER PARAMETERS

Parameter	Target	OK Minimum	OK Maximum
Salt	1,750 ppm	1,500 ppm	2,000 ppm
Calcium Hardness	50 ppm	25 ppm	75 ppm
Total Alkalinity	80 ppm	40 ppm	120 ppm
pH	7.4	7.2	7.8
Chlorine residual	3 ppm	1 ppm	5 ppm
Phosphates	< 150 ppb	0 ppb	300 ppb

SALT SYSTEM OUTPUT LEVELS

Level 0 System Off	Level 1 Vacation	Level 2–4 Low Output	Level 5–7 Normal Use (Recommended)
Level 8–9 High Use	Level 10 Maximum Output	Boost Level 10 for 24 hours	

AVAILABLE ON

Highlife® Collection — often standard / included on many models
Limelight® Collection — FreshWater IQ ready (Salt + Smart Monitoring + Dosing)
Hot Spot® Collection — Salt System optional

Always verify by model. Use only authentic Hot Spring / FreshWater titanium cartridges from an authorized dealer.
Water life up to 1 year depends on bather load and proper maintenance. Follow dealer start-up and care guidance.

SALT SYSTEM STARTUP GUIDE — 7 STEPS

1 TEST FILL WATER

Follow in order. Power OFF when spa is empty. Balanced fill water is the foundation of long-lasting clean water.

Before filling, take a sample of fill water to your dealer for metals, phosphates, and calcium testing.

- Metals: Iron & manganese below 0.5 ppm; copper below 0.2 ppm. Remove metals before startup if present. Strongly recommended: fill with FreshWater Clean Screen® Pre-Filter.
- Phosphates: Test with the provided kit. High phosphates feed algae and reduce salt system effectiveness — treat if elevated before proceeding.
- If liquid metal remover was used previously: clean filters and wait 24 hours before turning the salt system on or adding any chlorine.

2 FILL SPA

Install the salt system cartridge first (remove housing plug and save it in the equipment bay). Fill through the filter compartment to 1" (2.5 cm) above the highest jet.

- High metals or calcium in fill water: use Clean Screen® Pre-Filter and/or On The Go® portable softener as required by dealer guidance.
- Optional: insert FreshWater Mineral Spa Sanitizer (silver ion) cartridge now — inhibits bacteria growth and lowers ongoing chlorine demand.
- Power on per Owner's Manual. Set temperature $\geq 95^{\circ}\text{F}$. Set salt output to 0 (recommended for fill). Confirm jets work; leave jets running for salt addition.

3 ADD SALT

Target 1,750 ppm. Jets on, diverters mid-position. Start with half the chart amount; add one cup at a time into the filter compartment.

- Allow 5 minutes for salt to dissolve. Test with FreshWater Salt strips. Continue one cup at a time until ~1,750 ppm. Do not exceed 2,000 ppm.
- Approx salt amounts: 200 gal $\approx$ 4½ cups · 250 $\approx$ 5¾ · 300 $\approx$ 7 · 350 $\approx$ 8 · 400 $\approx$ 9¼ · 450 $\approx$ 10¼ · 500 $\approx$ 11½ · 550 $\approx$ 12½ · 600 $\approx$ 13¾ cups
- Typical starting output after salt is dissolved: Level 5–7 depending on spa volume (confirm capacity chart in the spa Owner's Manual).

4 BALANCE WATER

Test with FreshWater test strips. Bring pH and alkalinity into the salt-system range before continuing. Note calcium hardness for Step 6.

- Targets: Alkalinity 80 ppm (OK range 40–120) · pH 7.4 (OK range 7.2–7.8). Follow strip directions exactly for accurate readings every time.
- Adjust, retest, and repeat until balanced. Unbalanced water is the most common cause of startup problems and shortened cartridge life.
- Chlorine residual targets on strips may vary by country — consult local authority or your dealer for residual guidance in your area.

5 SANITIZE FILL WATER

All jets on, diverters mid. Add chlorine to the filter compartment per product label instructions. Target residual: 5 ppm.

- Run jets 5 minutes; test with a new FreshWater 5-Way strip. If under 5 ppm, repeat the dose. Wait 5 minutes between tests.
- Use liquid chlorine only — DO NOT use splash-free or scented bleach of any kind. Those products can interfere with the system.
- Critical step: skipping this can prevent the salt system from establishing a chlorine residual. Do not skip under any circumstances.

6 SOFTEN WATER

Target calcium hardness 50 ppm. Hard water damages equipment and reduces salt system effectiveness over time.

- 75–150 ppm: use the Vanishing Act® pillow included in the startup kit (follow Owner's Manual for soak time).
- 150–300 ppm: Vanishing Act XL or an On The Go® portable water softener from your dealer.
- Over 300 ppm: use On The Go during the fill process. After 24 hours retest; repeat until near 50 ppm. Discard used Vanishing Act in normal trash.

7 SET OUTPUT & MONITOR

Typically performed 24 hours after Steps 1–6 are complete. Set salt system output to the recommended level for your spa volume.

- Confirm chlorine residual of at least 3 ppm was maintained over the past 24 hours. If below, re-chlorinate to 5 ppm and press Boost.
- Repeat chlorination + Boost daily until the salt system independently holds ~3 ppm. Then fine-tune output level over the next few days of use.
- No measurable chlorine on a strip after 24 hours can mean the system is still cleaning contaminants — use Boost. This is normal and not a failure.

FRESHWATER® IQ — SALT + SMART MONITORING + DOSING

Three technologies. One seamless water-care experience.

SALT SYSTEM

Foundation of the system

- Generates chlorine from salt via titanium cartridge
- Continuous low-level sanitizer (target ~1–5 ppm)
- Cartridge lasts ~4 months; replace in seconds
- Output controlled 0–10 + Boost from spa panel
- Self-sanitizes the majority of the time
- Kit includes cartridge, controller, salt, strips

SMART MONITORING

The brain

- Checks pH, chlorine & salt levels every hour
- Status and guidance on spa screen or phone
- Clear step-by-step actions when levels drift
- Removes the guesswork from routine care
- Required for full FreshWater IQ operation
- Pairs with Salt System for automated insight

DOSING SYSTEM

One-touch balance

- pH Up (sodium bicarbonate) on demand
- pH Down (sodium sulfate) on demand
- Scheduled Phosphate Remover dosing
- Refillable cartridges under the filter lid
- Requires Salt + Smart Monitoring first
- Dealer-installed pump & chemical carrier

COMPATIBILITY & CAUTIONS

- Compatible with: chlorine (sodium dichlor / liquid sodium hypochlorite), MPS, and silver ion sanitizer cartridges.
- NOT compatible with: bromine, BaquaSpa® (biguanide), calcium hypochlorite, trichlor tablets, splash-free or scented bleach, scented oils, or silver nitrate products. Do not mix unsupported sanitizer systems with FreshWater IQ.
- Dosing System only functions when both the Salt System and Smart Monitoring System are installed and operational.
- Use only authentic FreshWater / Hot Spring cartridges and chemicals from an authorized dealer — counterfeits can damage the system.
- The spa owner is ultimately responsible for maintaining sanitary water. Follow local residual guidelines and dealer start-up advice.

TIPS FOR BEST PERFORMANCE

10-Day Checkup

Water care icon flashes every 10 days — test & balance water and confirm output level. Timer resets when you change output. If ignored: system drops to Level 3 after 15 days, Level 1 after 20 days.

Hold the residual

Test chlorine regularly. Adjust output up or down to maintain 3–5 ppm. Prefer changing output or using Boost before adding supplemental chlorine.

Balance first

Keep calcium, pH, and alkalinity in recommended ranges. Unbalanced water shortens cartridge life and reduces the effectiveness of the salt system.

Startup patience

If water was dirty or the spa is used heavily at first, it may take a few days to establish residual. Use Boost. No chlorine on a strip after 24 hrs can still mean the system is cleaning.

Cartridge care

Replace the titanium salt cartridge about every 4 months when prompted. Use authentic dealer cartridges only. Save the housing plug when you swap.

Dosing refills

Refill pH+/pH-/Phosphate cartridges when the spa prompts. Drain remaining pH solution before refill; phosphate liquid can be topped off. Rinse the funnel after each use.